St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
F.5 English Language
Grammar – Lesson 4: Cleft sentences

Name: _____
Class No.: _____
Date: _____

Cleft sentences

Part 1: Proofreading quiz

The following paragraph contains FIVE errors. The errors include **relative clauses**, **inverted patterns** and **parts of speech**. Proofread the paragraphs.

Argument for: Technology has made us lazier. (5 errors)

It is claimed that technology makes life easier, but the truth is far less pleasant. Not only teenagers order food instead of cooking, but they also replace real conversations with emoji-filled messages. They sit for hours on apps, that were designed to save time, and end up achieving nothing meaningful. The convenient of instant delivery has destroyed any reason to walk to the shops. Rarely parents notice that their children have forgotten how to hold a proper conversation. Only by encouraging teenagers to put down their phones the family can have a real conversation.

Part 2: Cleft sentences in formal writing

1. Why Use Cleft Sentences in DSE Writing?

> Cleft sentences (splitting a sentence into two clauses) allow you to **emphasize** critical arguments in essays, speech writings, or articles. They help to make your arguments more **persuasive.**

2. Key Cleft Sentence Structures

Type	Formula / Pattern	DSE Tech Example
It-Cleft	**It + is/was** + [Focused Element] + **that/who**...	**Original:** Social media addiction erodes face-to-face social skills among teens. It is **social media addiction** that erodes face-to-face social skills among teens. It is **face-to-face social skills** that social media addiction erodes among teens. It is **among teens** that social media addiction erodes face-to-face social skills.

Wh-Cleft	**What** [Clause] + **is/are** + [Focused Element]	Original: Young people need most today is a digital detox from constant notifications. What young people need most today is a **digital detox from constant notifications**. What young people need to do most today is **take a digital detox from constant notifications.** Those/The ones who need a digital detox most today **are young people.**
All-Cleft	**All** [that] [Clause] + **is/are** + [Focused Element]	**Original:** Algorithms only care about maximising user engagement. All (that) algorithms care about is **maximising user engagement.** All (that) algorithms do is **maximise user engagement.**

3. Practice Sets - Part A: Form It-Clefts

*Rewrite each sentence as an **It-Cleft**.*

1. The proliferation of smartphones has altered interpersonal communication patterns. [Focus on the proliferation of smartphones]

   _____

   _____

2. Tech companies prioritize profit over user privacy in the digital age. [Focus on the profit]

   _____

   _____

3. Gen Z teenagers spend most of their leisure hours on short-form video apps. [Focus on the apps]

   _____

   _____

4. Generative AI tools created widespread concern among secondary educators last year. [Focus on the AI tools]

   _____

   _____

5. Online anonymity encourages cyberbullies to post malicious comments. [Focus on the anonymity]

_____

_____

Part B: Form Wh-Clefts / All-Clefts

*Instructions: Rewrite each sentence as a **Wh-cleft / an All-cleft**.*

1. Excessive screen time damages sleep quality and mental well-being. [Wh-cleft: Focus on what damages sleep quality...]

_____

_____

2. The government should regulate misleading targeted advertisements on social media. [Wh-left: Focus on what the government should do...]

_____

_____

3. Modern teenagers desire instant validation through likes and comments. [Wh-cleft: Focus on who desires instance validation..]

_____

_____

4. Social media platforms aim to keep users scrolling as long as possible [All-cleft: Focus on what social media platforms aim to do..]

_____

_____

5. Cyberbullies hide behind anonymous profile pictures to cause harm. [Focus on what cyberbullies do...]

_____

_____

Part C: DSE Proofreading & Sentence Transformation (Paragraph Context)

Instructions: Read the student essay draft excerpt below. Rewrite the underlined plain sentences into cleft sentences (It-cleft, Wh-cleft, or All-cleft) to enhance emphasis and argument structure.

Student Writing Draft (HKDSE Essay - Topic: Digital Well-being)

While digital platforms promise seamless connectivity across global boundaries, many sociologists argue that hyper-connectivity actually breeds unprecedented emotional isolation. (1) **Standard messaging apps lack genuine emotional warmth**. As a result, online interactions often feel superficial, leaving young people feeling increasingly isolated despite being constantly reached by peers. To address this growing digital crisis, measures like banning mobile phones in schools are inadequate and fail to address the root cause. (2) **Schools need critical digital literacy education, not total phone bans**. Furthermore, tech monopolies intentionally design algorithms to keep users hooked for as long as possible. (3) **Social media algorithms only care about financial profit**. Ultimately, technology itself is neither inherently good nor evil; the key lies in how mindfully we choose to navigate the digital realm. (4) **Users require a conscious boundaries setting to regain control over their time**.

(1) _____

_____

(2) _____

_____

(3) _____

_____

(4) _____

_____